What Has Each of Us Been Told?

A guide to the family conversation about Medicaid and Mom's care: one sitting to put what each of you knows and has heard on one list.

Your brother was told at the facility that Mom has too much money. Your sister heard something different from a friend. You remember a name being added to one of Mom's accounts years ago, and you aren't sure whose. Each of you is working from a different version.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: put what everyone knows and has been told on one list. It isn't for deciding what to do about any of it.

Who should be there

Mom, if she is able and wants to be. Her spouse, if she is married. Then everyone who has been part of this: the one who talks to the business office, the one who pays her bills, the one who lives far away and has been reading about Medicaid at night. Someone who can't come can send notes ahead.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Start with what the conversation is for, and keep it small.

- “We've each heard something different about Medicaid. Before we do anything, let's get all of it on one page.”
- “Nobody has to be right today. We're writing down what we know, what we've been told, and what we don't know.”
- Say what the conversation isn't for: deciding whether Mom qualifies, or what to do with her money or her house.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom, if she is able

1. What would you like us to know about your accounts, the house and your insurance?

2. Have you given anything to anyone, or put anyone's name on an account or the house, that we should write down?

Ask each other

1. What have you been told about Medicaid and Mom, who told you, and when?

2. Going through the house, her bank and retirement accounts, her insurance and anything else she owns: what do you know about each one, and is that from a paper or from memory?

3. As far as you know, whose name is on the house and on each account?

4. What do you remember about gifts, transfers or changes in ownership, and roughly when?

5. Where does what you've heard differ from what someone else here has heard?

6. What don't any of us know yet?

How to write down what was said

Keep what you've been told separate from what you've seen on paper. Where two people heard or remember different things, write both and don't settle it. Both versions go to the professional as they are.

WHAT WAS SAID OR REMEMBERED	WHO SAID IT	WHERE IT CAME FROM	ON PAPER?
"Mom has too much money for Medicaid."	David	Someone in the admissions office, last week	No
Mom's name and Karen's are both on the savings account.	Karen	The bank statement	Yes. Karen has it

What not to decide yet

Each of these depends on the rules in Mom's state and on details a professional has to look at. Your list is what makes that look a good one. Leave them open.

- Whether Mom qualifies, or doesn't.
- Whether to spend, give away, move or retitle anything.
- Whether anything on the list of gifts and transfers matters.
- Whose version is the right one.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the list and send it to everyone.
- Who will look for each missing paper.

- Who will take each open question to the facility's business office, your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, decide what happens to any account or property, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets your family to one list, with the differences and the unknowns left on it. Medicaid rules vary by state, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has one list now instead of several versions. The planning interview takes that list further: it asks about your family's situation, question by question, and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for Mom's care.

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